

Question for a Uni Design Project: Is the massive energy footprint of AI actually on your radar?

Posted by u/TalNix77 • 0 points • 13 comments

Hi everyone,

I'm a design student researching the "invisible" energy consumption of AI for a university project.

While the utility of tools like Gemini is obvious, the physical resources required to run them are massive. Studies suggest that a single generative AI query can consume significantly more energy than a standard web search (some estimates range from 10x to 25x more).

I'm looking for honest perspectives on this:

1. **Awareness:** Before reading this, were you actually aware of the scale of energy difference between a standard search and an AI prompt? Or is that completely "invisible" in your daily usage?
2. **Impact on Usage:** Does the energy intensity play any role in how you use these tools? Or is the utility simply the only factor that matters for your workflow?
3. **Value vs. Waste:** Do you view this high energy consumption as a fair investment for the results you get, or does the current technology feel inefficient to you?

I'm trying to get a realistic picture of whether this topic actually plays a role in users' minds or if performance is the priority.

Thanks for your input.

Comments

u/bbwfetishacc • 1 points • 2025-12-06 09:40 UTC

i dont care really, also youre gonna get a fucking F if this is the thing you use to source your information instead of a google form or smth 🤔🤔🤔

u/Tasty_South_5728 • 1 points • 2025-12-06 08:50 UTC

The marginal economic output of AI will dwarf its power consumption. Focusing on TWh consumption instead of the trillions in new GDP is an accounting error, not a systemic ri

u/werddnum • 1 points • 2025-12-06 08:37 UTC

As I understand it, an AI prompt uses about as much energy as watching a few seconds of Netflix.

10-25x the energy of a search query is not much energy.

u/clayingmore • 1 points • 2025-12-06 04:49 UTC

I also run my air conditioner and drive a car. Why would I be worrying about a hundred AI queries?

It would make more sense to turn off my air conditioner for twenty minutes than to stop my AI use.

u/NoteEducational3883 • 0 points • 2025-12-05 23:47 UTC

Don't care

u/Onotadaki2 • 3 points • 2025-12-05 22:44 UTC

My read on the landscape is you have:

5 in 10 don't care.

4 in 10 knows about energy cost and will use like normal.

1 in 10 knows about energy cost and will actually curb use.

This is all going to space in five to ten years anyways, so I don't think it will achieve much impact pushing for changes. These are massive economic players. They can just buy out any government programs to keep using energy they need for scale.

u/Strong-Brill • 2 points • 2025-12-05 22:09 UTC

It is always a failed strategy of trying to make it about individual responsibility. This is the tactic that corporations use so they can continue to pollute.

If you look back on history, there are several cases like that famous Coca Cola ad featuring a crying Native American. It literally stopped essential reforms, and pushed the burden onto consumers which didn't even make much of an improvement in personal responsibility.

u/CaspinLange • 2 points • 2025-12-05 22:06 UTC

Electrification of the entire grid combined with decarbonization is the only answer, and it's already happening at an ever-growing rate.

The onus is not on individuals at all. It is on regulators and companies.

The costs of wind and solar are shooting downward so fast that this is where the smart money is going.

When it comes to wind and solar, Texas—where the land is cheap, the regulations are lax, and the winds blow a lot— is the leader out of all US states, generating nearly 30% of the nation's wind energy.

Lessons we can learn: make land affordable in windy areas, loosen regulations for clean energy projects.

u/toccobrador • 2 points • 2025-12-05 21:43 UTC

1) I'm aware that people say a lot of stuff but I don't think there's always good reason to believe that it is true. "How much energy an AI prompt uses" is going to be an extremely difficult thing to quantify, since there's zillions of different models and different prompts. I can run LLama-4b locally on my macbook on battery power and it doesn't even get hot, so don't tell me I'm burning up a small village's worth of water. If the AI company is paying for the power and I'm paying them for AI access, capitalism is working properly to distribute costs and resources. End of story.

2) Cost matters. To the extent that I have to pay for usage, I regulate my usage.

3) The high energy consumption storyline is bullshit so, well, n/a.

u/marx2k • 1 points • 2025-12-06 02:09 UTC

>The high energy consumption storyline is bullshit

How do you mean

u/Doppelkupplung69 • 6 points • 2025-12-05 21:35 UTC

Not really

No

¬_(ツ)_/

Here's what I know: my employer is Gaga for us to use AI, and our competition is using it to accelerate their deadlines and productivity. So I either use it to keep up or I lose my job.

u/Illustrious-Money-52 • 2 points • 2025-12-05 21:28 UTC

1. Yes I knew it and I know it very well.

2. Usefulness is the very first factor I take into consideration. Humanity's energy needs will rise more and more, so as I see it, AI is not the problem but the macro topic of the energy transition.

3. Complex question. Like any technology it can become more efficient and more functional. So no? I want him to continue to improve obviously.

u/Aggravating_Band_353 • 2 points • 2025-12-05 21:26 UTC

I just want answers and or help

Regulation of markets is a governmental topic

Putting the onus on the consumer to "make the right choice", which often is more expensive or restrictive or excludes them (ie, not self serving or beneficial) is an unnatural expectation.

We will be eating bugs because of this way of thinking. For the greater good (society has been replaced largely by corporations tho), not the good of the individual.